THE ALICE Y1 ARCHITECTURE DESIGN STUDIO PROGRAM

We live in a time when fundamental ecosystem disturbance announces its proximity through ecological precarity: abnormal climatic occurrences, pollution, and extinction (Tsing, 2018). It is essential that architecture adapts to this change and recognizes its complicity by questioning the foundational lessons inherited from our teachers, from history, and our practices as professionals. By questioning if these foundations are adequate. How should we learn from the incredibly rich and abundant environments built up by the many cultures of this planet, both human and non-human? We have a choice and an obligation in how we listen to the world, understand it, re-read it. We have a choice and an obligation as to which values we keep and which we may have to replace.

The ALICE Y1 architecture design studio program approaches this challenge to architectural practice in two ways. The first is its processual nature. Architecture does not belong to an abstract world conceived as a series of coherent problems, a world where architecture would form objects to solve those pre-defined problems. Rather, architecture is always entangled in questions directly linked to how we understand our existence and therefore emergent in nature. As gestures and inventions, architecture has both cultural and technical meaning. These two aspects of architecture cannot be separated as they are of one and the same nature. The things that we invent and produce to act upon the space and environment that we live in are extensions of our body. They are never static, but are in constant transformation, situated in relation to us as living individuals and societal beings, and in relation to the environment that is itself an evolving eco-system of other living organisms. Being alive, we—humans, plants, other species, our languages, our arts, our society—are intertwined in perpetually evolving relationships. Architecture is therefore both an expression and concretization of the relationships that we build with all life.

The second aspect that we stress in ALICE Y1 is architecture's collective nature. Architecture is never made alone; it is a means of communicating in society and with the environment. The collective languages by which we discuss architecture play a fundamental role in how we conceive of architecture itself. Gestures – the making and the significations that emerge through making – form a cultural and technical language that we craft together. We think, speak, and make architecture together. ALICE Y1 emphasizes the collaborative nature of architecture by making projects as individuals, in pairs, as small groups, as collectives, and as one large group of people. ALICE projects are collaborations with many public partnerships beyond the university. To emphasize the importance of the collective act, we have hypothesized, and succeeded, in thinking, designing, and building projects with 200 people and more, all authors and co-authors, as the culmination of the academic year.



The most important aspect in the ALICE series is however not the final form of the end-of-year construction, but rather the explorative processes of its contributors, and the capacity of an articulated mise-en-espace to support the search for new forms of living together: through architecture, we learn. As such, the ALICE series becomes a research agenda through which we not only build, but learn, architecture. Ways to co-inhabit, practicing collective acts, between us and a living environment. Will we, in such initiation, reconsider our individual responsibilities ?

Lessons from collective practice require regular periods of reflection: what have we learned—about architecture, community needs, and local environments—as we develop projects collectively? How can this knowledge evolve, for both pedagogy and practice, enabling students and teachers alike to continuously improve their ways of working?

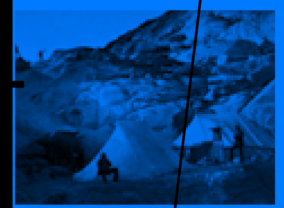
Following the single-year cycles of INSIDE (2015–2018) and BECOMING (2018–2021), ALICE adapted its pedagogical approach towards a more continuous and attentive process of knowledge acquisition. RESONANCE was a multi-year cycle structured around four annual stages: FOUNDATIONS (2022–2023), PLANES (2023–2024), ROOMS (2024–2025), and PLAY (2025–2026). In May 2026, the cycle concluded with a series of interventions that prefigured future uses of the Battelle-Tambourine park in Carouge.

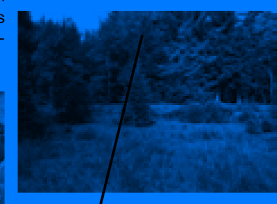
MATERIAL LANDSCAPES
For the years 2026–2029, ALICE launches the new cycle Material Landscapes, an architectural design studio program combining territorial analysis, interdisciplinary spatial programming, and hands-on design–build experience. Addressed to first-year EPFL students, the program is developed in close collaboration with local communities, cultural institutions, and private stakeholders. Its approach is explicitly transscalar, moving from territorial conditions to material details, allowing students to engage with architectural methods and tools while developing concrete proposals for architectural and landscape projects.

The Material Landscapes program explores how the material conditions of a territory, together with its built and unbuilt landscapes, reflect the social, ecological, and economic processes that shape them. It investigates the emergence of ecological continuities and niches in urban and rural contexts through interactions between species and environments, while examining the disruptions generated by dominant and extractive systems. In response to these challenges, which are central to the climate emergency, the program focuses on regenerative practices seeking to restore material, ecological, and affective connections. It proposes that caring for ecological, social, and material interdependencies can contribute to the transformation of our environments and support a shift from extractive to regenerative modes of production and inhabitation.

Within this framework, Material Landscapes approaches territories as situated conditions, revealing the relationships and interdependencies that define them. Architectural and landscape interventions are developed in collaboration with local human and non-human communities, drawing from situated knowledge and existing practices. Projects respond to both the needs and potentials of each territory, operating as forms of architecture-infrastructure: spaces that foster dialogue, support shared forms of life, and contribute to ongoing discussions about the transitions required by contemporary societies.

MATERIAL LANDSCAPES
2026–2027: ÎLES
LA CHAUX-DE-FONDS
The first year of the cycle, ÎLES, is developed in collaboration with La Chaux-de-Fonds Swiss Cultural Capital 2027 (lcdf27). La Chaux-de-Fonds occupies a unique position in Switzerland and Europe, recognized for its exceptional architectural and urban heritage. The city is the birthplace of Marie-Elsa Sgualdo, Henriette Grandjean, Charles-Édouard Jeanneret (Le Corbusier), Blaise Cendrars,or Louis Chevrolet. It is also renowned for its distinctive urban structure, known as «Urbanisme Horloger.» Shaped by its specialized watchmaking economy and the architectural typologies developed for workshops and industrial infrastructures, the city has developed a unique identity and morphology. In 2027, it will become the first Swiss city to hold the title of «Swiss Cultural Capital.»





Like any city, La Chaux-de-Fonds is deeply connected to its territory. During the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, watchmaking became the region's defining activity. Production methods and technological innovations, combined with highly specialized craftsmanship, transformed the area into the world's leading watchmaking center. The development of the *établissage* system—a decentralized production model based on specialized skills in the fabrication and assembly of watch components—allowed farmers practice in watchmaking during the winter months. This created a specific ecology of learning, where agricultural knowledge, artisanal expertise, and territorial resources became closely interconnected. Some of these practices continue today.

At the same time, the region was integrated into a wider interregional network long before the emergence of modern nations. Watchmaking depended on materials and resources requiring complex processes of extraction, transformation, and refinement, while finished watches circulated globally. Material Landscapes seeks to reveal these historical and contemporary relationships between resources, territories, processes, and knowledge, exploring their potential for future transformation.

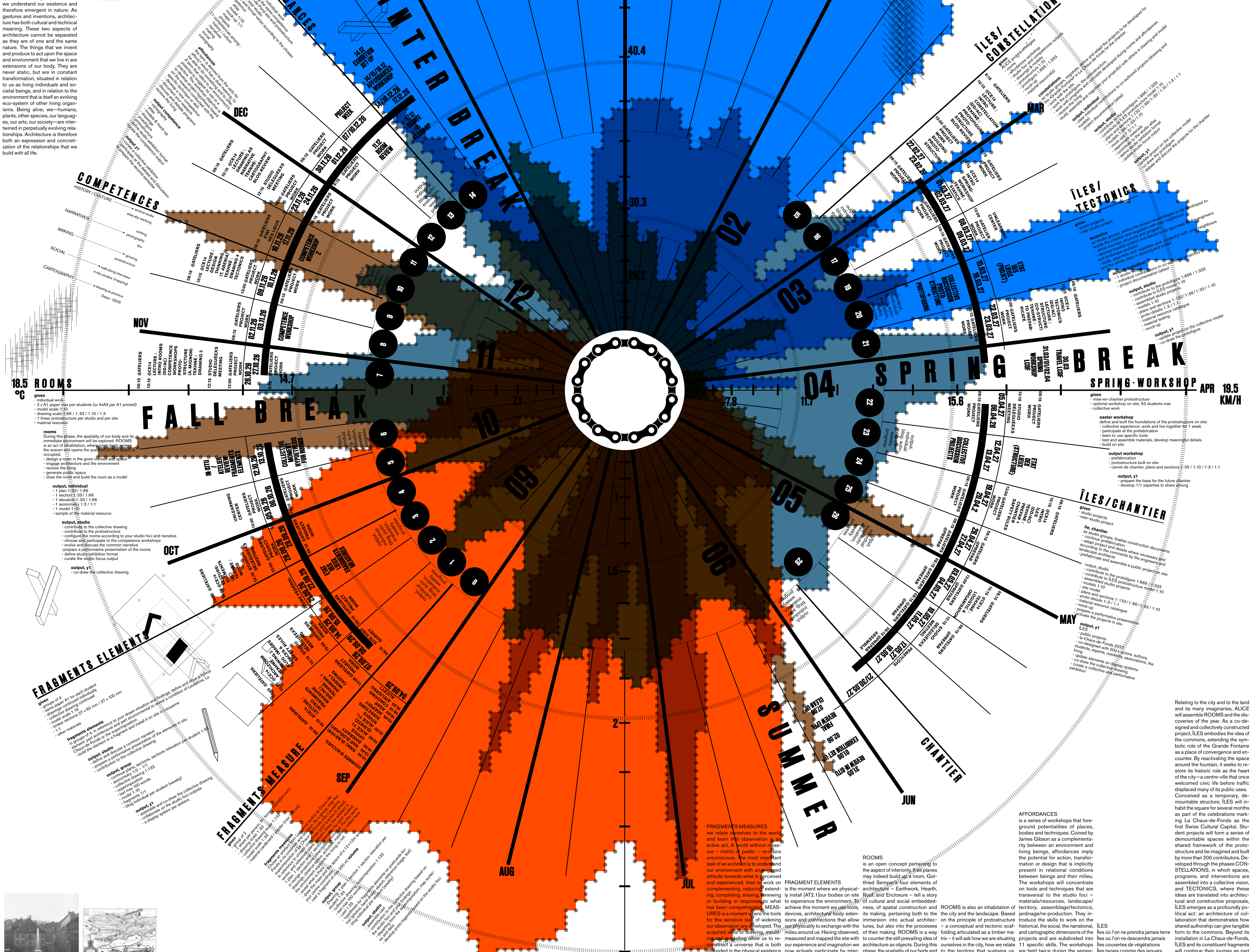
Innovation in the region extended beyond watchmaking. In the eighteenth century, La Chaux-de-Fonds and Neuchâtel were home to some of the first humanoid automata. Created by Pierre Jaquet-Droz, these mechanical figures—the Writer, the Draughtsman, and the Musician—were capable of writing, drawing, and playing music through sophisticated mechanical systems. Presented throughout Europe, they embodied the region's unique combination of craftsmanship, technology, and imagination.

After the fire of 1794 destroyed much of the city, La Chaux-de-Fonds was rebuilt through a collective effort and according to an urban plan directly influenced by watchmaking. Designed by watchmaker Charles-Henri Junod, the plan introduced narrow blocks that provided optimal daylight for workshops requiring precise manual work. The city became an extension of its productive practices. Today, this unique urban structure is recognized as a UNESCO World Heritage Site. In 1867, Karl Marx described La Chaux-de-Fonds in Das Kapital as an «immense factory town,» highlighting the organization of labor within the Jura watchmaking industry.

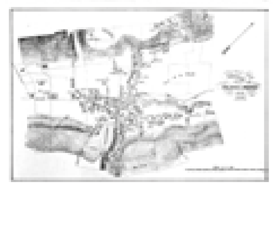
Although the city never reached the scale imagined by nineteenth-century visionaries, it has preserved a rare spirit of innovation and a distinctive identity, surrounded by a remarkable landscape accessible directly from Boulevard Léopold-Robert, its main urban axis.

DESIGN–BUILD INSTALLATION SITE: GRANDE FONTAINE
Boulevard Léopold-Robert, known locally since the nineteenth century as «the Pod,» functions as the city's urban stage—a place to see and be seen. It culminates at the Grande Fontaine, built in 1885 to celebrate the arrival of running water and symbolize progress. Beneath it flows the Ronde River, now hidden within an underground canal. While modern infrastructures made water accessible and reliable, they also concealed the territories and resources that sustain everyday life.

For Easter 2027, as part of La Chaux-de-Fonds Swiss Cultural Capital 2027, ALICE will mount a protostructure around the Grande Fontaine. From May 2027 onwards, this structure will become an experimental public space for La-Chaux-de-Fonds and its visitors. Conceived as a three-dimensional canvas, it will evolve over time: perhaps becoming a lantern illuminating the fountain? A luminous cloud above the Pod? an archive of landscape stories? A narrator of the fountain's possible histories? Or simply a place where children can play with water ?









FRAGMENTS MEASURES
we relate ourselves to the world and learn that observation is an active act. A world without measure – metric or poetic – remains unconscious. The most important task of an architect is to understand our environment with an engaged attitude towards what is perceived and experienced, then to work on complementing, reducing, extending, completing, erasing, renewing or building in response to what has been comprehended. MEASURES is a moment where the tools for this sensitive task of widening our observation are developed. The acquired skills of drawing, moulding and modelling allow us to reconstruct a universe that is both grounded in the physical existence of the world we live in and in the mind we dwell in. Three figures of the La-Chaux-de-Fonds territory are superimposed onto Lausanne where MEASURES will take place. Both territories strictly oriented North, the 'Grande Fontaine' is superimposed onto the 'Fontaine de la Justice' at place Palud in Lausanne.

FRAGMENT ELEMENTS
is the moment where we physically install [AT2.1]our bodies on site to experience the environment. To achieve this moment we use tools, devices, architectural body extensions and connections that allow our physicality to exchange with the milieu around us. Having observed, measured and mapped the site with our experience and imagination we now actively participate by interacting with it through a minimal architectural intervention that acts as a mediator. 1:1 scale will be employed for this endeavour so that all the three actors — body and consciousness; architectural device; territory or context — become real and at the same scale, intertwining to become one same storyline.

ROOMS
is an open concept pertaining to the aspect of interiority. If six planes may indeed build up a room, Gottfried Semper's four elements of architecture – Earthwork, Hearth, Roof, and Enclosure – tell a story of cultural and social embeddedness, of spatial construction and its making, pertaining both to the immersion into actual architectures, but also into the processes of their making. ROOMS is a way to counter the still prevailing idea of architecture as objects. During this phase, the spatiality of our body and its immediate environment[AT3.1] will be explored. Following the assimilation of how planar elements can form specific spatial conditions that relate to existing ones, ROOMS is an act of inhabitation, where one's body «enters the scene» and opens the question of how space is occupied.

ROOMS is also an inhabitation of the city and the landscape. Based on the principle of protostructure – a conceptual and tectonic scaffolding articulated as a timber matrix – it will ask how we are situating ourselves in the city, how we relate to the territory that sustains us, how we make a living, and how we share space between us humans while relating to life on the planet. ROOMS will tell stories about the land, the vegetation, the seasons, the materials that are sourcing our lives and livelihoods – stories about the people and their intertwined histories with the living in this place.

AFFORDANCES
is a series of workshops that foreground potentialities of places, bodies and techniques. Coined by James Gibson as a complementarity between an environment and living beings, affordances imply the potential for action, transformation or design that is implicitly present in relational conditions between beings and their milieu. The workshops will concentrate on tools and techniques that are transversal to the studio foci – materials/resources, landscape/territory, assemblage/tectonics, jardinage/re-production. They introduce the skills to work on the historical, the social, the narrational, and cartographic dimensions of the projects and are subdivided into 11 specific skills. The workshops are held twice during the semester and culminate into a multiday collective work at the end of the semester. They redistribute student skills transversally across studios while students inscribe themselves according to their choice. Each of the 11 subthemes will produce a collective output as a documentations of collective research.

ÎLES
Îles où l'on ne prendra jamais terre
Îles où l'on ne descendra jamais
Îles couvertes de végétations
Îles tapies comme des jaguars
Îles muettes
Îles immobiles
Îles inoubliables et sans nom
Je lance mes chaussures par-dessus bord car je voudrais bien aller jusqu'à vous

(Blaise Cendrars, Feuilles de route). 1924

Relating to the city and to the land and its many imaginaries, ALICE will assemble ROOMS and the discoveries of the year. As a co-designed and collectively constructed project, ÎLES embodies the idea of the commons, extending the symbolic role of the Grande Fontaine as a place of convergence and encounter. By reactivating the space around the fountain, it seeks to restore its historic role as the heart of the city—a centre-ville that once welcomed civic life before traffic displaced many of its public uses. Conceived as a temporary, demountable structure, ÎLES will inhabit the square for several months as part of the celebrations marking La Chaux-de-Fonds as the first Swiss Cultural Capital. Student projects will form a series of demountable spaces within the shared framework of the protostructure and be imagined and built by more than 200 contributors. Developed through the phases CONSTELLATIONS, in which spaces, programs, and interventions are assembled into a collective vision, and TECTONICS, where these ideas are translated into architectural and constructive proposals, ÎLES emerges as a profoundly political act: an architecture of collaboration that demonstrates how shared authorship can give tangible form to the commons. Beyond its installation in La Chaux-de-Fonds, ÎLES and its constituent fragments will continue their journey as part of the ALICE ATLAS exhibition in 2028, which presents the Living Labs developed by ALICE in public spaces across Europe. ÎLES situates the immense fragility of life in the thinness of the biosphere. As a collective we hope to nurture the notion of care in our non-built and built environments.